Workplace Governance in the Age of ESG and Digitalization: Union Influence in Liberal Market Economies*

Thomas Kiu[1], William Yeoh[2], Li Zhao[3] and Yingwei Chen[4†]
School of Business and Hospitality Management Saint Francis University, United States
tkiu@sfu.edu.hk
Lee Shau Kee School of Business and Administration Hong Kong Metropolitan University, Hongkong
wyeoh@hkmu.edu.hk
International Business College Shandong Technology and Business University, China
202214055@sdtbu.edu.cn
Manchester Law School Manchester Metropolitan University, Manchester, United Kingdom
y.chen@mmu.ac.uk

Abstract

This article examines how union members shape the workplace governance of environmental, social and governance (ESG) practices and digitalization in two liberal market economies: Ireland and the United Kingdom. While scholarship commonly treats ESG as a firm-level reporting/governance domain and digitalization as a technological or work-design issue, this study foregrounds union members as workplace actors who mediate how sustainability and digital technologies are translated into rules, practices, and voice arrangements at work. The article adopts a comparative qualitative design based on documentary and textual analysis of policy and regulatory materials, union and confederation documents, public guidance on industrial-relations procedures, and relevant comparative scholarship. Findings show that union-member influence is conditioned by shared transition pressures, such as concerns over surveillance, insecurity, and fragmented voice, yet varies systematically with national institutional pathways. In Ireland, influence is more strongly supported by institutional mediation and forms of bargaining coordination, enabling unions to connect digital change to broader

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† Corresponding author

sustainability and worker-welfare agendas. In the United Kingdom, influence depends more on workplace recognition and hybrid repertoires that combine formal representation with informal organizing, legal claims, and public campaigning. Across both cases, ESG and digitalization generate a dual dynamic: they intensify workplace risks while also opening opportunities to reframe employment relations around accountability, participation, and responsible governance. The article contributes to debates on labour governance by linking ESG and digitalization to worker voice and by conceptualizing union members as mediating agents in workplace transformation. Approaches confirms high internal consistency of the interpretation

1 Introduction

Digitalization and environmental, social, and governance (ESG) agendas increasingly intersect through the information infrastructures, metrics, reporting routines, and algorithmic systems that translate societal expectations into organizational practice (Sun et al., 2024; Tőzsér et al., 2024). As firms adopt analytics, AI-based decision tools, and platform technologies, ESG commitments intensify demands for accountability and responsible governance (Parker & Grote, 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021). This convergence matters because it is not confined to reporting or technology adoption alone: it is increasingly worked out through workplace governance, reshaping job quality, surveillance, participation, and the distribution of worker voice in sociotechnical change (Berg et al., 2023; Grimshaw et al., 2023).

Yet existing research has not adequately explained how this governance nexus is constructed at workplace level. ESG scholarship continues to focus largely on firm-level disclosure, governance, and performance outcomes (Sun et al., 2024; Tőzsér et al., 2024), while research on digitalization has primarily examined work design, algorithmic management, and job-quality effects (Parker & Grote, 2022; Berg et al., 2023). Employment-relations research has paid closer attention to the collective regulation of technological change, but has given less sustained attention to how ESG governance intersects with worker voice as digital systems are implemented and routinised (Doellgast & Wagner, 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021). As a result, scholarship still knows too little about how union members, through bargaining, organizing, and framing, shape the governance of ESG and digitalization as these agendas converge.

This omission matters because ESG and digitalization are not parallel developments but overlapping governance regimes. ESG functions as an accountability regime, introducing disclosure requirements, metrics, and normative expectations around responsible conduct, while digitalization operates as a control and coordination regime through data infrastructures, monitoring systems, and algorithmic decision-making. In practice, the two are increasingly interdependent: ESG commitments rely on digital systems for data capture, reporting, and verification, while digital technologies generate governance problems (e.g., surveillance, algorithmic bias, and workforce fragmentation that fall directly within the social and governance dimensions of ESG) (Sun et al., 2024; Parker & Grote, 2022; Grimshaw et al., 2023). Their convergence, therefore, produces a common workplace-governance dynamic in which accountability logics and technological control jointly shape job quality, participation, and worker voice. (e.g., For workers and their representatives, this creates a dual dynamic: digitalization can intensify monitoring, insecurity, and work pressure, yet ESG frameworks can also provide a language of accountability through which such risks are contested and negotiated) (Berg et al., 2023; Woodcock & Cant, 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021).

This article addresses that gap by foregrounding union members as mediating workplace actors whose influence depends on mobilized power resources and institutional pathways (Lévesque &

Murray, 2010; Refslund & Arnholtz, 2022). We compare Ireland and the United Kingdom as most-similar liberal market economies with different routes to worker voice: Ireland features stronger institutional mediation and some bargaining coordination, whereas the United Kingdom relies more heavily on workplace recognition as the gateway to bargaining influence (O'Connell, 2021; DETE, 2025; WRC, 2025; ACAS, 2026; GOV.UK, 2026). Using comparative document analysis, we ask: (1) how do union members influence the integration and governance of digital tools and ESG practices in workplaces? and (2) what repertoires do they deploy to balance innovation with worker protection across institutional contexts? In doing so, the article makes three contributions: it reconceptualises ESG and digitalization as a workplace governance regime, specifies how union members translate these pressures into workplace arrangements, and develops a pathways argument showing how national institutional routes condition the form, timing, and scope of union-member influence.

2 Related Work

2.1 ESG, Digitalization, and Employment Relations

Existing research on ESG and digitalization primarily follows three streams, each offering valuable insights yet leaving an important workplace-governance gap. The first stream conceptualizes ESG and digitalization mainly as governance and performance phenomena, emphasizing how sustainability reporting regimes, non-financial accountability, and digital transformation reshape corporate governance structures and external stakeholder monitoring (Tőzsér et al., 2024; Sun et al., 2024). This work is especially useful for explaining why firms adopt ESG disclosure practices and how digital transformation can strengthen or weaken governance through data visibility and reporting infrastructures (Sun et al., 2024; Tőzsér et al., 2024). However, these studies often treat ESG as a boardroom- and reporting-centered governance architecture, leaving under-specified the workplace-level mechanisms through which ESG commitments are translated into rules, routines, and decision rights that affect employee participation, consultation, and the everyday governance of work. Put differently, ESG is frequently analyzed "above" the workplace, even though the implementation of ESG targets commonly relies on digital systems that reorganize work processes and accountability in ways that directly implicate workers.

The second stream examines digitalization through the lens of work design and job quality, showing how digital tools and automation reshape worker autonomy, monitoring, pacing, and work intensity (Parker & Grote, 2022; Berg et al., 2023). This literature provides strong evidence that digital systems are not neutral instruments; rather, they embed managerial assumptions about control, performance measurement, and discretion, with consequential effects for job quality and wellbeing (Parker & Grote, 2022; Berg et al., 2023). Yet the dominant framing remains largely focused on proximal work-design outcomes, how technologies alter tasks and discretion, while giving less systematic attention to digitalization as an employment-relations issue that is governed through collective bargaining, representation, and institutionalized voice. This omission becomes particularly consequential in fragmented and non-standard work contexts, including gig and platform work, where employment status ambiguity and weak representation can intensify exposure to surveillance and unilateral algorithmic control (Wu & Huang, 2024).

A third stream, closer to employment relations, focuses on how digitalization intersects with worker voice, collective regulation, and institutional mediation. Research in this stream argues that digital

transformation is not solely a technical implementation challenge but a contested process shaped by collective action and the institutional conditions of voice and bargaining (Doellgast & Wagner, 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021). It highlights how unions and worker representatives mobilize narratives, solidarity, and institutional resources to negotiate or resist monitoring, restructuring, and work reorganization associated with new technologies (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Doellgast & Wagner, 2022). However, this stream has less consistently integrated ESG as a governance frame that can reshape the terrain of digitalization, both by providing new legitimacy resources for worker claims (e.g., accountability, participation, responsible governance) and by introducing new metrics and compliance routines that may reinforce managerial control (Grimshaw et al., 2023).

Taken together, these streams leave unresolved how ESG (as an accountability regime) and digitalization (as a control and coordination regime) interact at the workplace level, and how union members mediate that interaction through voice, bargaining, and hybrid influence strategies. Addressing this gap requires bringing ESG governance into closer conversation with employment relations and sociotechnical change, focusing on the workplace institutions and practices through which "responsible" digital transformation is actually governed.

2.2 ESG and Digitalization in the Workplace: Key Challenges and Opportunities for Union Members

The intersection of digitalization and ESG governance presents both challenges and opportunities for unions because it reconfigures the "rules of the game" through which work is designed, monitored, and justified. Digitalization changes not only tools but also governance arrangements by embedding evaluation, coordination, and control into data infrastructures (e.g., performance metrics, monitoring systems, algorithmic scheduling), while ESG introduces accountability logics that elevate questions of fairness, participation, and responsible conduct (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Parker & Grote, 2022; Sun et al., 2024). In this setting, unions become pivotal actors for safeguarding worker welfare, not simply by defending existing terms and conditions but by shaping how digital and ESG commitments are translated into workplace practices (Pulignano et al., 2026; Wilkinson et al., 2021). Digital technologies can reduce discretion and intensify work through real-time monitoring and data-driven targets, increasing the salience of union intervention to secure transparency, contestability, and voice in technology governance (Parker & Grote, 2022; Berg et al., 2023). At the same time, ESG can supply unions with new frames and legitimacy resources, such as "responsible governance" and "stakeholder accountability", that allow traditional employment concerns (e.g., privacy, work intensity, training, job security) to be advanced as governance issues rather than isolated grievances (Grimshaw et al., 2023; Wilkinson et al., 2021).

Institutional context strongly conditions how unions can act on these challenges and opportunities. In Ireland, the legacy of social partnership and the presence of institutional mediation have enabled unions to engage more directly in shaping policy discourse and national-level approaches to digital transformation and sustainability, providing pathways to link worker voice to ESG integration beyond individual workplaces (O'Connell, 2021; DETE, 2025; WRC, 2025). Such supports can facilitate more coordinated bargaining agendas around skills, consultation, and safeguards against adverse consequences of automation and data-driven management (Pulignano et al., 2026; Parker & Grote, 2022). By contrast, unions in the United Kingdom operate in a more fragmented industrial relations environment in which influence often hinges on workplace recognition and firm-level bargaining access, and where unions may need to combine formal negotiation with informal organizing and broader public strategies, especially in platform-mediated and non-standard work settings (Woodcock & Cant, 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021). This contrast suggests that the same ESG–digitalization pressures can yield

different patterns of union influence depending on whether institutional supports enable coordinated engagement or whether influence must be assembled through hybrid repertoires across dispersed workplaces (Doellgast & Wagner, 2022; Keizer et al., 2024).

A complementary explanation comes from union power and capacity research. In fragmented and non-standard employment contexts, unions' ability to shape digital governance depends less on formal presence alone and more on mobilizing power resources: internal solidarity, strategic narratives, organizational capabilities, and institutional links that convert workplace concerns into collective demands (Lévesque & Murray, 2010; Refslund & Arnholtz, 2022). This is especially pertinent for platform work and other forms of fragmented employment, where work is organized across multiple entities and where conventional voice channels are weakened (Grimshaw et al., 2023; Woodcock & Cant, 2022). In such settings, unions may need to blend bargaining with organizing, litigation, and public campaigning to secure protections and recognition, illustrating how power resources shape diverse strategies and outcomes (Keizer et al., 2024; Woodcock & Cant, 2022). Digitalization thus becomes a contested governance process in which union influence is mediated by the availability of institutional access points and the capacity to mobilize resources to make algorithmic control and ESG accountability actionable workplace issues (Doellgast & Wagner, 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021).

Finally, unions' engagement with CSR/ESG is increasingly relevant as a bridge between workplace regulation and broader societal governance. Where firms frame digital transformation as innovation and ESG compliance as responsible conduct, unions can press for commitments that ensure these agendas produce social value rather than shifting risks onto workers, particularly in the gig economy and platform work where employment protections are uneven (Woodcock & Cant, 2022; Wu & Huang, 2024). This includes advocating legal and regulatory reforms that embed ESG principles into digital labor governance (e.g., transparency, accountability, and protections against unfair monitoring), so that platform workers are not excluded from the "S" in ESG during digital transition (Keizer et al., 2024; Grimshaw et al., 2023). In this sense, unions can act as governance intermediaries, translating ESG claims into concrete safeguards and participation mechanisms that shape how digital systems are designed, deployed, and contested at work (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Doellgast & Wagner, 2022).

2.3 Understanding Union Member Responses to ESG and Digitalization

Recent research treats union responses to workplace change less as direct reactions to external pressures than as processes through which workplace issues become collective and actionable. This is particularly relevant to ESG and digitalization, where many workplace changes emerge through monitoring systems, performance metrics, compliance routines, restructuring, and changing skill demands rather than through immediately visible industrial relations conflict (Pulignano et al., 2026; Wilkinson et al., 2021). Within this literature, research on union power and capacity provides the main analytical foundation. Union influence is linked not simply to formal position or membership size, but to the mobilization of solidarity, organizational links, narratives, and institutional resources (Lévesque & Murray, 2010; Refslund & Arnholtz, 2022). In this formulation, workplace pressures become consequential when they can be connected to collective meanings and forms of action.

This emphasis on mediation is extended in research on technological change. Studies of Industry 4.0 show that workplace discontent is framed around issues such as well-being, job insecurity, and work quality, and that these framing processes are associated with different bargaining and mobilization outcomes (Pulignano et al., 2026). Comparative studies of unions and digitalization similarly show that the effects of technological change vary with how change is interpreted and negotiated in different organizational and national settings (Lloyd & Payne, 2023; Payne et al., 2023). Across this literature, framing links technological and governance change to collective concerns. A related literature examines

how digitalization alters the organizational conditions of voice and representation. Studies of worker voice show that digitalization changes both the channels of voice and the conditions under which concerns are collectivized (Wilkinson et al., 2021). Research on fragmented work further shows that representation becomes more difficult where work is organized through subcontracting, platforms, and inter-organizational relations rather than within a single employing organization (Grimshaw et al., 2023). The literature on precarious and platform work develops this point further by showing that responses vary with available power resources, institutional supports, and organizational channels, and may combine formal bargaining, informal networks, legal claims, and public campaigning (Keizer et al., 2024; Woodcock & Cant, 2022).

By focusing on union members, we refer not to individual attitudes but to how members, acting through representative roles, mobilization, and institutional channels, mediate workplace governance outcomes. In documentary analysis, this influence is observed through claims, procedural rights, and negotiated rules attributed to member action rather than organizational headquarters alone.

3 Theoretical framework

This study draws on Sociotechnical Systems Theory and Power Resource Theory to explain how union members mediate the governance of ESG and digitalization at the workplace level. Together, these perspectives illuminate both why worker participation matters in digital transformation and how union-member influence varies across institutional contexts.

3.1 Sociotechnical Systems Theory and Inclusive Digital Governance

Sociotechnical Systems Theory provides a foundational lens for understanding why union engagement is consequential in processes of digital transformation. Classic sociotechnical accounts argue that organizational performance and sustainability depend on the joint optimization of social and technical subsystems, rather than on the unilateral implementation of technological solutions (Emery & Trist, 1960; Cherns, 1976). From this perspective, workplace technologies are not neutral tools but social arrangements that embed assumptions about control, coordination, and discretion. As digital systems reshape task allocation, monitoring, and decision-making, their effects on job quality, autonomy, and participation become central to organizational outcomes.

Applied to contemporary digitalization, sociotechnical theory suggests that inclusive digital governance is not merely an ethical aspiration but a design principle. When algorithmic management, data-driven performance systems, and platform technologies reorganize work, the availability of worker voice and participation conditions whether these systems generate sustainable performance or instead produce hidden costs such as stress, insecurity, resistance, and disengagement (Parker & Grote, 2022; Berg et al., 2023). Sociotechnical theory therefore supports treating union interventions, such as consultation rights, bargaining over monitoring and data use, commitments to training and upskilling, and procedures for contesting data-driven decisions, as governance mechanisms that align technological change with worker welfare and long-term organizational sustainability (Parker & Grote, 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021).

3.2 Power Resource Theory and Union-Member Influence

While sociotechnical theory explains why participation matters, Power Resource Theory (PRT) helps explain why union-member influence over the governance of ESG and digitalization varies across

workplaces and national systems (Korpi, 1998). In PRT, union power is not reducible to membership density or formal recognition alone; rather, influence depends on the capacity to mobilize and combine multiple power resources, including internal solidarity, organizational infrastructure, strategic framing and narratives, expertise, and institutional linkages (Lévesque & Murray, 2010; Refslund & Arnholtz, 2022). These resources enable unions and their members to transform diffuse workplace concerns into collective claims that are actionable in bargaining, legal, and public arenas.

PRT is particularly relevant in the context of ESG and digitalization, where governance issues often emerge indirectly through monitoring systems, performance metrics, compliance routines, and platform-mediated work arrangements that fragment voice and complicate representation (Grimshaw et al., 2023; Wilkinson et al., 2021). From a power resource perspective, unions' capacity to shape responsible digital governance, for example, by limiting surveillance, securing consultation rights, or linking upskilling and job security to sustainability commitments, depends on whether they can leverage institutional supports (such as mediation bodies or coordinated bargaining) and/or deploy hybrid repertoires that combine formal representation with organizing, legal strategies, and public campaigning (Keizer et al., 2024; Woodcock & Cant, 2022).

3.3 Integrating the Two Perspectives

Taken together, Sociotechnical Systems Theory and Power Resource Theory provide a complementary framework for analyzing union-member influence over ESG and digitalization.

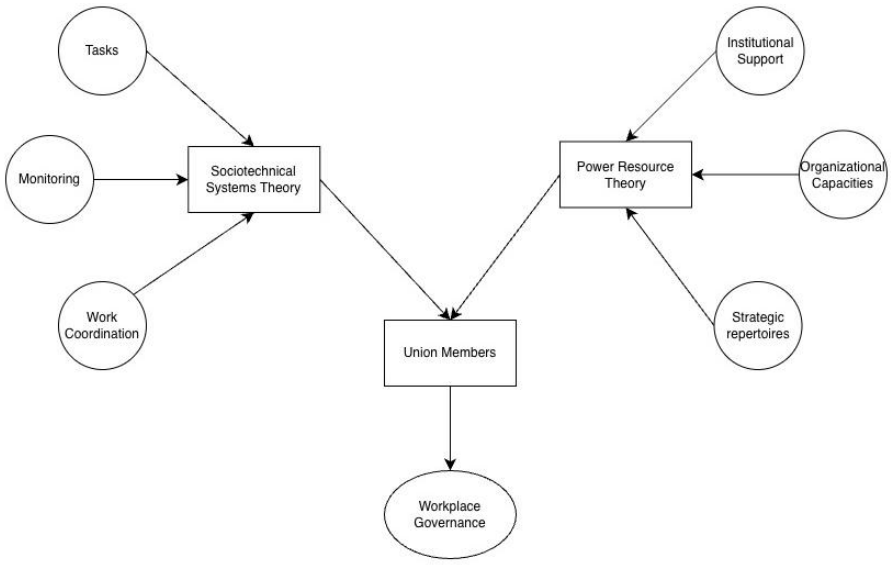


Figure 1: Union Member and the Governance of ESG and Digitalization

Figure 1 illustrates the theoretical framework guiding this study. Drawing on Sociotechnical Systems Theory and Power Resource Theory, the framework conceptualizes union members as mediating actors in the workplace governance of ESG and digitalization. Sociotechnical Systems Theory highlights that digital technologies reshape tasks, monitoring, and coordination, and that their outcomes depend on the joint optimization of social and technical subsystems; from this perspective, worker voice and participation are integral to sustainable digital governance rather than residual concerns. Power Resource Theory complements this view by explaining how union-member influence

varies across institutional contexts, emphasizing that governance outcomes depend on the mobilization of power resources such as institutional supports, organizational capacities, and strategic repertoires. Positioned at the center of the framework, union members translate ESG commitments and digital systems into workplace governance practices, such as consultation rights, rules on monitoring, training provisions, and mechanisms for contesting data-driven decisions. The framework therefore links technological design and accountability regimes to concrete governance outcomes at work, while highlighting how institutional pathways condition the capacity of union members to shape the governance of ESG and digitalization.

4 Case Selection and Research Methods

4.1 Comparative design and case logic

This study adopts a comparative qualitative case-study design centred on Ireland and the United Kingdom, selected through a most-similar systems design to examine how comparable institutional environments generate divergent patterns of union-member influence. Both countries are well-established liberal market economies characterised by decentralized bargaining structures and voluntarist industrial-relations traditions, which helps hold constant key macro-institutional features relevant to workplace governance. They also share a common Anglo institutional heritage, including historically similar legal foundations governing employment and collective representation, making them analytically comparable. This most-similar comparison allows the study to hold constant the broader liberal-market context while isolating variation in the institutional pathways through which worker voice is organised and union-member influence is exercised.

Despite these similarities, the two countries differ in the institutional mechanisms through which union-member influence can be exercised. In Ireland, institutional mediation and elements of bargaining coordination provide more structured supports for worker voice, whereas in the United Kingdom influence depends more heavily on workplace recognition and firm-level bargaining access. This difference is central to the article's pathways argument.

4.2 Ireland: voluntarism with institutional mediation and coordination

Ireland is analytically relevant because it combines a voluntarist industrial-relations tradition with continuing forms of institutional mediation. Official policy documents characterize Irish industrial relations as essentially voluntary, but established institutions, especially the Workplace Relations Commission (WRC) and the Labour Court, provide formal mechanisms for conciliation, dispute resolution, and procedural support that can indirectly strengthen collective voice by structuring how disputes are processed and how bargaining is sustained (DETE, 2025; WRC, 2025). Recent policy developments, particularly Ireland's Action Plan to Promote Collective Bargaining 2026–2030, further signal an active state interest in strengthening collective bargaining capacity (DETE, 2025). In addition, recent scholarship suggests that, despite Ireland's liberal market setting, meaningful forms of bargaining coordination persist in some sectors (O'Connell, 2021; Paolucci & Roche, 2024).

4.3 United Kingdom: decentralized voluntarism with statutory recognition

The United Kingdom is analytically relevant because it combines decentralized voluntarism with a

statutory route to union recognition. Where voluntary recognition is not granted, unions may apply for statutory recognition through the Central Arbitration Committee (CAC), making workplace recognition a key institutional gateway for enforceable union influence and collective bargaining access (ACAS, 2026; GOV.UK, 2026.). Compared with Ireland, this institutional configuration places greater weight on recognition status and workplace-level bargaining access, and less on national-level institutional mediation.

4.4 What the comparison is designed to reveal

The comparison is designed to reveal whether similar ESG and digitalization pressures generate different forms of union-member influence when access to worker voice is institutionally structured in different ways. By comparing two broadly similar liberal market economies, the study controls for major political-economic differences while focusing on variation in mediation, coordination, and recognition as routes to workplace influence. The aim is therefore not to contrast fundamentally different industrial-relations regimes, but to explain how different institutional pathways shape the form, scope, and timing of union-member influence over workplace governance.

4.5 Data and analytic approach: documentary and textual analysis

The study is based on documentary and textual analysis, which is appropriate because the article focuses on how union-member influence is institutionally structured and publicly articulated, rather than on estimating prevalence or reconstructing the full range of private perceptions. It examines how workplace mediation is institutionally structured and rendered visible through documentary traces such as claims, disputes, procedural activations, and negotiated outcomes (Bowen, 2009). In line with Prior's (2003) view of documents as embedded in social action rather than as passive records, the analysis treats policy texts, adjudication decisions, procedural guidance, and union materials as evidence of mediating processes and documented causal mechanisms through which workplace governance is articulated and contested. This interpretation is consistent with mechanism-oriented qualitative research that uses documentary evidence to assess how causes contribute to outcomes through intervening processes (Beach & Pedersen, 2019; Collier, 2011).

The study is based on documentary and textual analysis, which is appropriate because the article focuses on how union-member influence is institutionally structured and publicly articulated, rather than estimating prevalence or reconstructing the full range of private perceptions. The evidence base consists of four types of material: (1) official policy and regulatory documents, (2) publicly available trade union and confederation materials, (3) public industrial-relations guidance on recognition and dispute resolution, and (4) secondary scholarly work in comparative employment relations and union studies (Doellgast & Wagner, 2022; OECD & AIAS, 2025a, 2025b).

Analytically, this design enables the study to trace (i) the institutional channels through which union voice can be exercised (e.g., mediation bodies, recognition procedures), and (ii) how ESG and digitalization are framed as legitimate objects of workplace governance within public policy texts, union strategies, and guidance on collective procedures. By triangulating across the four document types, the analysis supports a comparative account of how similar transition pressures are translated into different repertoires of union-member influence under distinct institutional conditions.

Within this design, union-member influence is operationalized through workplace-level representation and participation rather than as an attribute of unions as centralized organizations. The analysis interprets documentary evidence such as adjudication decisions, policy submissions, and procedural guidance as reflecting member-level influence when they capture claims, disputes, and negotiated outcomes rooted in workplace interactions, including issues related to monitoring, data use,

job quality, and training. These documents frequently reflect the role of workplace representatives (e.g., shop stewards or employee representatives) in articulating and advancing such concerns through institutional channels.

This analytical distinction separates member-level influence from broader union organizational strategy or leadership discourse. While national unions and confederations frame policy positions and strategic priorities, the documents examined here provide insight into how workplace-based concerns are mobilized and translated into governance outcomes. Evidence is therefore attributed to union-member influence where it reflects the activation of procedural rights, dispute mechanisms, or negotiated changes linked to workplace-level representation, rather than solely top-down policy articulation. This approach enables the study to examine how union members function as mediating actors connecting institutional structures with concrete workplace governance practices.

Table 1. Ireland and the United Kingdom as comparative cases

	Ireland	**United Kingdom**	**Analytical relevance**
Market economy Structure	Liberal market economy	Liberal market economy	Holds broad context constant
Union Density	22.2% (2024)	22.0% (2024)	Comparable membership base
Bargaining Coverage	34% (latest available year: 2017)	40.2% (2024)	Different bargaining reach
Predominant Bargaining Level	Local/company level	Local/company level	Similar decentralization
Key Institutional Support	WRC, Labour Court, collective bargaining action plan	CAC statutory recognition route	Distinguishes pathways of influence
Likely Route of Union-Member Influence	Institutional mediation and bargaining coordination	Workplace recognition and firm-level bargaining access	Clarifies comparative expectation

Note. Union density, bargaining coverage, and bargaining level are drawn from OECD and AIAS (2025a, 2025b). Information on Ireland's industrial-relations institutions is drawn from DETE (202 5) and WRC (2025). Information on UK statutory recognition is drawn from GOV.UK (2026) and ACAS (2026).

5 Findings

5.1 Union Member Influence in Ireland

We observe three recurring mechanisms through which union members in Ireland shape the workplace governance of ESG practices and digitalization. First, institutional mediation via the Workplace Relations Commission (WRC) and the Labour Court channels workplace concerns into formal dispute resolution and policy frameworks. For example, published WRC adjudication decisions and Labour Court recommendations concerning workplace monitoring, data use, and technological change illustrate how disputes over digital systems are translated into negotiated rules on consultation, fairness, and procedural transparency (DETE, 2025; WRC, 2025; O'Connell, 2021). These documented cases demonstrate how union concerns about surveillance and work intensification are addressed through institutionalized mechanisms rather than remaining informal grievances.

Second, coordinated bargaining agendas translate ESG commitments into concrete workplace arrangements. Evidence from sectoral agreements and national policy documents, including Ireland's Action Plan to Promote Collective Bargaining 2026–2030, shows how unions link digital transformation to commitments on training, skills development, and worker protection (DETE, 2025; Pulignano et al., 2026; Parker & Grote, 2022). In these materials, digitalization is not treated purely as a technical upgrade but is embedded within broader frameworks of sustainability, job quality, and responsible governance.

Third, unions actively reframe digital change as a sustainability issue. Union submissions to public consultations and policy documents routinely position concerns such as job security, well-being, and work–life balance as core elements of ESG outcomes. This reframing enables unions to convert risks associated with monitoring and algorithmic control into enforceable governance claims grounded in established institutional procedures (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Berg et al., 2023).

5.2 Union Member Influence in the United Kingdom

In contrast, the documentary analysis reveals that UK union members exercise influence through hybrid, recognition-dependent repertoires that are often assembled at the workplace level. First, where statutory recognition is secured through the Central Arbitration Committee (CAC), unions are able to formalize bargaining over digitalization-related issues. CAC decisions and ACAS guidance on collective bargaining indicate that disputes over workplace technologies frequently involve demands for data transparency, consultation rights, and safeguards against unfair monitoring practices (ACAS, 2026; GOV.UK, 2026; Wilkinson et al., 2021). These documented cases show how ESG-related concerns, particularly around fairness and accountability, are translated into formal bargaining agendas.

Second, in fragmented and platform-mediated contexts where recognition is absent or contested, unions rely on alternative forms of influence. Publicly documented campaigns and legal cases involving platform workers, for example, disputes over algorithmic management, employment status, and digital surveillance, illustrate how unions mobilize ESG narratives in external arenas (Woodcock & Cant, 2022; Grimshaw et al., 2023; Keizer et al., 2024). In these cases, unions frame issues such as opacity in algorithmic decision-making and exclusion from employment protections as failures of the "social" dimension of ESG. This demonstrates how, even outside formal agreements, concrete disputes and campaigns provide empirical evidence of unions using ESG frameworks to challenge the governance of digital work.

5.3 Cross National Pattern

The comparison yields a clear institutional divergence alongside strategic convergence. Ireland's mediated and coordinated pathway produces proactive, policy-linked influence that embeds worker voice early in national digital and sustainability agendas. The United Kingdom's recognition-centric model generates more contingent, hybrid influence that compensates for fragmentation through multi-arena mobilisation.

Yet both cases display the same underlying dual dynamic, in which digitalization simultaneously generates workplace risks while ESG frameworks create new opportunities for contestation and governance. In Ireland, for example, unions use institutional mediation and coordinated bargaining to respond to risks associated with algorithmic monitoring and work intensification by embedding ESG-framed safeguards, such as consultation rights, limits on surveillance, and commitments to training and upskilling, directly into negotiated arrangements. Here, the expansion of digital monitoring technologies increases managerial control, yet ESG accountability logics enable unions to reframe these risks as governance issues requiring transparency and worker participation (OECD & AIAS, 2025a, 2025b; Doellgast & Wagner, 2022). A comparable pattern emerges in the United Kingdom, albeit through different mechanisms. In recognized workplaces, unions translate ESG language into formal demands for data transparency and contestability of algorithmic decisions, illustrating how digital systems that intensify surveillance also generate pressure for accountability. In platform-mediated and non-standard work settings where recognition is limited, unions mobilize legal claims and public campaigns to highlight exclusions from the "social" dimension of ESG, particularly among gig workers exposed to insecure and data-driven work arrangements. In these contexts, the very features of digitalization that weaken traditional voice channels, such as fragmentation and algorithmic control, simultaneously create legitimacy gaps that unions exploit through ESG narratives. Taken together, these examples demonstrate that the ESG–digitalization nexus produces a consistent dual dynamic across both cases: digital technologies intensify control, monitoring, and fragmentation, while ESG provides a normative and institutional framework through which these developments can be contested, reframed, and governed. These patterns are consistently reflected in published adjudication decisions, policy documents, and union campaign materials across both cases.

5.4 Comparative Synthesis

The comparative analysis underscores the critical role of institutional context in shaping union responses to ESG governance and digital transformation. In Ireland, unions benefit from state-backed social dialogue, which facilitates collective bargaining and ESG integration within broader societal goals. In contrast, UK unions operate within a more fragmented framework, relying on workplace-level bargaining and hybrid organizing strategies to address ESG concerns and digital challenges (Doellgast & Wagner, 2022). Despite these differences, both sets of unions have recognized the need to integrate digitalization and ESG principles into worker advocacy, ensuring that workplace transformation occurs in ways that protect job quality and worker rights (Lévesque & Murray, 2010; Payne et al., 2023).

6 Disscussion

This study shows that the convergence of ESG and digitalization is best understood as a workplace governance issue rather than simply a matter of corporate reporting or technological implementation

(Sun et al., 2024; Tőzsér et al., 2024). Union members emerge as mediating actors who translate broad sustainability commitments and digital pressures into concrete workplace concerns, including monitoring, job quality, consultation, training, and the contestability of data-driven decisions (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Doellgast & Wagner, 2022). The findings therefore suggest that the meaning of ESG and digital transformation is shaped not only by managerial strategy or regulatory discourse, but also by how worker voice is organized and exercised at workplace level (Parker & Grote, 2022; Berg et al., 2023).

The comparison further highlights that union-member influence is institutionally conditioned. In Ireland, institutional mediation and elements of bargaining coordination support a more proactive and policy-linked form of influence, enabling unions to connect digital change to broader agendas of worker welfare and responsible governance (O'Connell, 2021; DETE, 2025; WRC, 2025). In the United Kingdom, by contrast, influence depends more heavily on workplace recognition and is often assembled through hybrid strategies combining formal bargaining, organizing, legal claims, and public campaigning (ACAS, 2026; GOV.UK, 2026; Woodcock & Cant, 2022). Although these institutional pathways differ, both cases show unions addressing similar governance issues, particularly transparency, participation, training, and protection against unilateral managerial control (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Keizer et al., 2024).

These findings support the article's integrated theoretical framework. From a sociotechnical perspective, the evidence reinforces the view that digital systems are not neutral tools, but forms of workplace organization whose outcomes depend on how technical change is aligned with social arrangements such as participation, consultation, and worker protection (Parker & Grote, 2022; Berg et al., 2023). From a power resource perspective, the study shows that union influence depends not simply on formal presence, but on the capacity to mobilize institutional access, collective organization, and strategic framing (Lévesque & Murray, 2010; Refslund & Arnholtz, 2022). Taken together, the findings suggest that responsible digital transformation is more likely when workers have meaningful channels through which to influence how new systems are introduced and governed (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Doellgast & Wagner, 2022).

The analysis also extends existing ESG scholarship by showing that ESG commitments gain substantive meaning only when they are translated into workplace rules and practices. Much of the existing literature treats ESG largely as a firm-level reporting and accountability framework (Sun et al., 2024; Tőzsér et al., 2024), yet the findings here indicate that its social and governance dimensions are worked out in everyday employment relations (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Grimshaw et al., 2023). Digitalization intensifies this dynamic because the same systems that increase monitoring and managerial control also generate new demands for transparency, accountability, and contestability (Parker & Grote, 2022; Berg et al., 2023). ESG therefore does not simply sit alongside digitalization; it provides a language and governance frame through which the consequences of digital change can be challenged and negotiated (Grimshaw et al., 2023; Sun et al., 2024).

More broadly, the article contributes to employment-relations research by linking digital transformation and ESG governance within a common analytical framework. Rather than treating technological change, sustainability, and worker voice as separate domains, the findings show that they are increasingly intertwined in the governance of contemporary work (Doellgast & Wagner, 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021). The comparison between Ireland and the UK further demonstrates that even among similar liberal market economies, national institutional pathways shape the form and scope of union-member influence (O'Connell, 2021; OECD & AIAS, 2025a, 2025b). This underlines the importance of examining workplace transformation not only through firm strategy or technological capability, but also

through the institutions and power relations that structure employee voice (Lévesque & Murray, 2010; Refslund & Arnholtz, 2022).

Overall, the discussion points to a clear conclusion: credible ESG governance and sustainable digital transformation depend on workplace arrangements that make worker voice effective (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Parker & Grote, 2022). Union members are significant in this process because they connect abstract commitments on responsibility and innovation to concrete issues of fairness, participation, and protection at work (Doellgast & Wagner, 2022; Berg et al., 2023). Their influence may follow different institutional routes, but in both cases it is central to how the ESG–digitalization nexus is governed in practice (Keizer et al., 2024; Woodcock & Cant, 2022).

7 Theoretical implication

The findings suggest that responsible digital transformation cannot be achieved through ESG disclosure or technology adoption alone; it requires workplace governance arrangements that give workers a meaningful role in how digital systems are introduced and used (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Parker & Grote, 2022). For employers, this means embedding ESG principles into day-to-day management practices through clear limits on monitoring and data collection, transparent criteria for algorithmic decision-making, formal consultation before implementation, and investment in training and upskilling linked to technological change (Berg et al., 2023; Sun et al., 2024). These measures can help reduce resistance, strengthen legitimacy, and improve the quality of digital transformation by aligning technical change with worker welfare and participation (Parker & Grote, 2022; Doellgast & Wagner, 2022).

For unions, the results highlight the strategic value of using ESG as a governance framework for bargaining and worker representation. Rather than treating ESG as a largely corporate or reputational agenda, unions can translate it into enforceable workplace demands, including rights to consultation, transparency over data use and performance systems, protections against excessive surveillance, and procedures for contesting algorithmic decisions (Wilkinson et al., 2021; Grimshaw et al., 2023). The comparison also suggests that strategy should reflect institutional context: where mediation and coordinated bargaining are available, unions may pursue broader standard-setting around digital governance; where recognition is more fragmented, influence may depend on combining workplace bargaining with organizing, legal action, and public campaigning, particularly in platform and non-standard work (Keizer et al., 2024; Woodcock & Cant, 2022).

For policymakers, the study indicates that effective ESG governance requires institutional frameworks that make worker voice part of the governance of digital work. This includes strengthening consultation rights, supporting collective bargaining structures capable of addressing digitalization, and ensuring that regulatory approaches to algorithmic management incorporate principles of transparency, fairness, and contestability (Doellgast & Wagner, 2022; Wilkinson et al., 2021). The comparison between Ireland and the United Kingdom further suggests that where institutional supports for mediation and collective voice are stronger, unions are better able to shape digital change in ways that connect innovation with worker protection and broader sustainability goals (O'Connell, 2021; OECD & AIAS, 2025a, 2025b).

Overall, the practical implication is that credible ESG governance depends on whether firms, unions, and policymakers treat worker voice as an operational feature of digital transformation rather than a secondary concern. If ESG is to have substantive meaning in the context of digitalization, it must be

translated into concrete workplace protections and participation mechanisms that address the realities of monitoring, data-driven management, skill change, and job security (Parker & Grote, 2022; Berg et al., 2023). In this respect, worker voice is not external to ESG delivery but central to whether digital transformation can be regarded as responsible in practice (Sun et al., 2024; Wilkinson et al., 2021).

This article makes three theoretical contributions that extend, existing ESG and employment-relations theory. First, it reconceptualizes ESG and digitalization as a workplace-governance nexus by adding a meso–micro analytical layer to predominantly firm-level ESG frameworks, showing how accountability systems and digital infrastructures are enacted through workplace rules, practices, and voice arrangements. Second, it advances a theoretically grounded explanation of union-member influence by specifying the mechanisms, particularly bargaining, framing, and mobilisation, through which these governance pressures are translated into concrete workplace outcomes. Third, through a most-similar comparison of Ireland and the United Kingdom, it develops a pathways argument showing that the form and effectiveness of this translation are conditioned by institutional routes to worker voice. Overall, the article offers a structured theoretical extension that connects ESG governance, digitalization, and employment relations more systematically, rather than redefining ESG theory itself.

8 Practical implications

In terms of unions, the findings underscore the strategic value of linking ESG narratives to specific, enforceable workplace governance demands. Such demands include negotiated constraints on surveillance and monitoring, transparency and access to data about performance systems, contestability mechanisms for algorithmic or metric-driven decisions, and commitments to training and job security during digital transition. The contrast between Ireland and the UK further suggests that union strategy should be calibrated to institutional pathways: where mediation and coordination are available, unions can seek broader standard-setting and policy linkage across sectors; where recognition is contingent, unions may need to build hybrid repertoires combining workplace bargaining with organizing, legal action, and public campaigning to secure protections in platform and non-standard work. Developing internal expertise in digital governance and ESG accountability can also strengthen unions' ability to convert abstract commitments into operational safeguards and participation mechanisms, particularly where work is organized through dispersed digital infrastructures.

Limitations

Several limitations qualify the interpretation of these findings, particularly in relation to the study's reliance on documentary and textual analysis. While this approach is well suited for examining institutional structures, formal governance arrangements, and publicly articulated repertoires of union influence, it necessarily captures official, codified, and strategic representations rather than the full complexity of workplace-level dynamics. Documentary sources may reflect normative positions, policy intentions, or union strategies, but they do not directly observe how these are enacted, negotiated, or contested in everyday practice. As a result, the analysis may understate informal interactions, micro-level resistance, and variation across firms and sectors.

In addition, documentary analysis is subject to issues of selectivity and representational bias, as available texts are shaped by institutional visibility and publication practices. Some forms of union activity, particularly informal organizing or case-specific bargaining outcomes, may be less systematically documented and therefore less visible in the analysis. Similarly, employer perspectives and the technical design features of digital systems, such as algorithmic decision rules or monitoring architectures, are not directly examined, limiting insight into how governance arrangements operate in

practice.

A further limitation is that the method does not allow for causal inference or process tracing at the workplace level. While the study identifies patterned relationships between institutional pathways and repertoires of union-member influence, it cannot definitively establish how specific governance outcomes emerge through interaction among actors in particular organizational contexts. Future research could address these limitations by combining documentary analysis with qualitative case studies, interviews with union representatives and managers, and, where feasible, direct examination of workplace governance artefacts such as collective agreements, monitoring policies, and algorithmic management protocols. Such multi-method approaches would provide a more fine-grained understanding of how ESG and digitalization are negotiated and implemented in practice.

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